

Morality and religion



Philosophy developed from the human desire to find rational explanations for things without recourse to religion. The increasing sophistication of Greek society led to a feeling that, despite a still-widespread belief in the gods and their influence in the world, they had become more remote from human life. Most philosophers saw religion as irrelevant to their thinking, but with the emergence of moral philosophy the question of divine influence resurfaced.

Plato tackled this problem in his dialogue *Eurthyphro*, posing the question: 'Is the pious loved by the gods because it is pious, or is it pious because they love it?' In other words, is our morality determined by religion, or do we devise it ourselves and incorporate it into our religion? Plato took this further, suggesting that we have some innate concept (in his terms, a knowledge of the Forms) of good and evil. This question of how far morality is human or God-given became a particular preoccupation for medieval Christian and Islamic philosophers.